



Toy Story

Toy Story was the first completely computer generated animation, and came from Pixar in 1995



Avitel Post Studioz

We have a look around in one of the country's leading animation and post production houses, bringing you the dirt on how they work, and juicy details on the equipment they use.

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Avitel is a post production, visual effects and animation company that has an illustrious history of thirty-five years. The office and animation wing is located at Mahim, Mumbai, and the studio wing, which houses the post production facility, is located at Juhu, Mumbai. Avitel offers a wide range of services to its clients, and works on the aspects of cinema that are not in public view.

Dr. Pradeep Jain founded Avitel in 1972, and at that time it was the first private post production studio. Till then, post-production work was done by Doordarshan itself. *Yeh Jo Hai Zindagi* and *Mukkad* were among the first of many television serials that were post-produced by Avitel. Television advertisements came along with the onset of television, and there were a lot of special effects work involved for these commercials, a market which Avitel dominated. Avitel steadily grew in the field of post-production, with a history of many firsts. These included conversion to Telecine, reverse Telecine, and introduced digital post-production to India in 1992. Avitel was also the first to start mastering VCDs and DVDs in India, with record numbers of films mastered (1,200 for VCDs and 6,000 for DVDs). Recently, the Content Architecture and Design (CAD) wing of the company has been established for making animated full-length feature films.

The CAD department takes care of the entire animation process, which includes both pre-production and production.

The pre-production aspect of animation requires a lot of brain storming and ideation. The concept designer comes up with a story idea, or a skeleton for a film. The script writer develops and writes the story, which is then converted to a script. The director is consulted at this point, and the script is given a cinematic treatment – which involves the technical details and storyboarding. The script doctor consults with the technical team, and a final script, which is the foundation for the animation, is prepared. Based on the script, the characters are designed and developed. This stage also includes the modelling and the rigging of



The Animation Technology team



Concept designing



The Pre-Production unit

the characters. A character is made to look and move in a certain way in this process. The production of the animation starts only after this.

Indian animation studios had a lot of production work previously, but were not involved in pre-production. Avitel has successfully conceptualised and sold four films to a UK-based company, Purple Passion Productions. The films will be sold as a one time sale. The studio is geared entirely towards the international market, as the quality of their content is not justified by the current revenue stream of Indian animations. This is because of a lack of an audience; an overseas animated feature makes much more than an Indian animation film.

Avitel currently has a team of 80 animators, who work at the Mahim office. They are looking to expand to a facility that allows for 500 animators, and they plan to hire 300 animators over the course of the next three years, which is the development schedule for the movies that they have sold to their overseas clients. The studio works mostly on Dell machines, which are upgraded according to the requirements of the engineers in the organisation. Everyone in the organisation are technocrats, and

intimately involved in the technologies that the studio uses. The CAD division recruits freshers from animation schools, and then trains them for the organisation itself. As advice to budding animators, Dr. Pradeep Jain encourages going through an animation school, and then specialising in one aspect of animation.

Animation grabs a fair share of the limelight, and quite a few people are aware of modelling and basic animation, which can be done on household computers as well. Post-production, on the other hand, requires expensive equipment, and the intricacies of the operation are beyond common public knowledge. The post production wing of Avitel is at Juhu, and occupies two floors of a well decorated office. There are cartoons all over the walls of the studio, and the best equipment in the world is used.

There are two departments in the post-production studio, the digital intermediate department, and the commercial or broadcast department. The digital intermediate department converts data from one format to another, while the broadcast department handles all the colour-correction, editing, transitions and the like. Most of the work comes into the studio in film reels,